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The Editor-in-Chief
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Dear Editor-in-Chief,

We respectfully submit our manuscript, **"NARCIS: Authenticated Neural Coverless Image Signaling with Attack-Qualified Codebooks and Error Correction,"** for consideration as a Research Paper in *Computers & Security*.

Scope Fitness Assessment. NARCIS addresses secure multimedia communication through unchanged natural images. It combines an invariant descriptor, balanced codebooks, attack-qualified selection, finite-index feasibility, AES-GCM protection, replay rejection, and Reed–Solomon correction. It therefore concerns information hiding, multimedia security, active-channel robustness, and authenticated communication.

- **Security:** success requires exact authenticated plaintext recovery, rather than descriptor accuracy alone.
- **Operation:** an alphabet is accepted only when every coded symbol has sufficient qualified covers in the finite index.
- **Evaluation:** calibration and holdout attacks are separated; selection leakage is tested with statistical, residual, and CNN detectors.

Scientific Contribution and Evidence. Across five deterministic partitions each of BOSSBase and RGB Caltech-101, all 1,575 clean, calibration, and holdout message-condition trials recovered the authenticated plaintext. Mean symbol accuracies were 98.74% and 98.59%. A matched BOSSBase ablation fell from 210/210 to 142/210 recoveries without qualification. At a 16-symbol operating point, net rate increased from 0.184 to 1.213 bits/cover for 8- to 128-byte payloads. Calibration-locked projection selection increased the minimum stable bucket from 92 to 161 on the evaluated BOSSBase partition. The paper also reports a weak Caltech-101 selection signal (repeated CNN AUC 0.533, 95% CI [0.517, 0.548]) and makes no general undetectability claim.

Positioning. Unlike work centred on nominal hash length or single-image mapping capacity, NARCIS tests whether a complete protected message can be realised by a finite index and recovered after declared distortions. Its position is protocol completeness and verified operating-point selection, not universally maximal capacity.

Mandatory Author Declarations.

- **Originality/exclusivity:** The manuscript is original, unpublished, and not under consideration elsewhere.
- **Author approval:** All authors approved the manuscript, order, contributions, and submission.
- **Interests/funding:** No competing interests or external funding are declared.
- **Ethics/reproducibility:** No humans, animals, or personal data are involved. Code, seeds, evidence, tests, and sources are available at github.com/EkodeckStephane/NARCIS.

The manuscript fits the journal's readership at the intersection of information security, robust image communication, and reproducible protocol evaluation. Thank you for considering this submission.

Yours sincerely,

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